

However, Microsoft fails to address one of the biggest issues in buying a computer – the operating system. Sure, you will get hardware that is a lot more cutting edge for a \$1,500 laptop PC than you would on a MacBook of the same price. But when you consider that the latter is running OSX, which requires a lot fewer resources than Windows and is much simpler and better to use, does the price not seem valid?

Microsoft has to sell its products and an ad is hardly ever going to be fair; our only point with this little piece of information is that operating systems (OS) and platforms are an integral part of a buying decision, and the factor is no different in the case of mobile phones.

Largely, there are three popular base platforms for cell phones in India: Windows Mobile, Symbian S60 and Java. Of course, there is a fair portion of the audience that uses the Blackberry platform on devices made by Research In Motion, Palm OS on their Palm handsets and the iPhone OS. We are not ignoring these, but given the constraints of editorial space and Google's Android (more on this in the 'What's Next' section) is yet to come around to our shores, so we have discounted those.

Java, by itself, is not an operating system. Like its counterpart for the PC, this is a platform that runs on top of any OS. This lets programmers transcend the constraints of the base OS and deliver their software to a wider audience. Indeed, you will be hard pressed to find phones that do not support Java, and as such, it is the most widely-used platform. The popularity of Java is largely due to the fact that most cell phone manufacturers, such as Nokia, Sony Ericsson, Motorola, etc., have a proprietary light OS for their low- to mid-end phones. The common thread between all these phones is Java, and hence it makes sense for developers to code their software for an all-encompassing platform.

As for Symbian, Nokia has championed its cause for a long time now. The majority of its business-oriented E-series as well as its high-end N-series of phones use the Symbian Series 60 (S60) 3rd edition operating system. Even some LG, Samsung and Sony Ericsson phones now come preloaded with Symbian-based operating systems, including the heavyweight Omnia HD and the much-hyped 12-megapixel touting Sony Idou. Newer offerings, like the touchscreen 5800 XpressMusic and the